

SCORE
BOARD The Image Editing Software

	Adobe Photoshop 6.01	Gimp 1.2	Jasc Paintshop Pro 7	Micrografx Picture Publisher 9	QFX 7
Contact Details	Adobe Systems India Pvt. Ltd	The Gimp Organisation	Jasc Software	Micrografx	QFX Software
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Web site	www.adobe.com	www.gimp.org	www.jasc.com	www.micrografx.com	www.qfx.com
Price	Rs 39,456	Freeware	Rs 5,995	Rs 3,317 approx (\$69.95)	Rs 18,920 approx (\$399)
Features					
(i) Layers	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Only in Draw mode
(ii) Filters	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
(iii) Masking	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
(iv) Support For Scanner	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
(v) Support for CMYK	Yes	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Drawing tools	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Importing images from scanner	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
File saving formats supported	JPEG, GIF, TIFF, PSD, etc	Cannot save in TIFF and GIF formats	JPEG, GIF, TIFF, PSD, etc	PPF and BMP only	JPEG, GIF, TIFF, PSD, etc
Ratings	A-	B	B+	B	B-

help but fails to provide sufficient information, as most of the help sections seem to be under construction.

Micrografx provides a decent set of help files and the developers have taken the pain to explain many features through visual examples.

Coming back to Adobe Photoshop, the help files are really impressive with a lot of attention paid to detail. These files include a portrayal of image editing fundamentals along with descriptions of each and every tool and feature in the software aided by illustrative examples.

A price to pay

Does it make sense to buy expensive software if you're not going to use the extra features? Obviously not, so you, as the end user, must identify the purpose you need the software for, and then opt for the right software. The reason is simple: professional software doesn't come cheap.

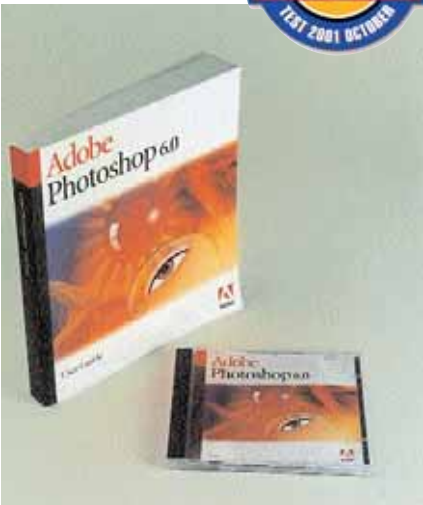
The extremely functional Adobe Photoshop 6 costs approximately Rs 39,456 while the equally versatile Jasc Paint Shop Pro7 costs Rs 5,995. So if you are not going to use the full potency of Photoshop and can compromise on certain functionalities, then Paint Shop Pro should be a reasonably cheap and justifiable option.

QFX7 gives you a shock with a price tag of Rs 18,920 for something that is not so fundamentally brilliant. Micrografx is available for approximately Rs 3,500, providing a good solution for home users.

CONCLUSION

In this software shootout, one can see that each software reviewed offers easy-to-use features and tries extending its functionalities by bundling an animation package so as to not disappoint the Web community.

However, given the range of features and the functionality offered, **Adobe's Photoshop** emerges the clear winner. QFX7 seemed to be the worst software to deal with. It did provide some decent functionality but as far as the interface and operations go, it is not worth the money. Gimp does offer some competition to Photoshop



Adobe Photoshop 6: the most functional and versatile image editing software

but it loses out on stability, interface and support for CMYK. Micrografx Picture Publisher boasts some very cool filters but it does not have any blending modes for the layers and neither can it save in the most commonly used file extension such as JPEG, GIF, TIFF and PSD.

The only software that provides stiff competition to Photoshop is JASC Paint Shop Pro7. It stands second in our ratings as it provides all functionalities which a graphic professional would look for—colour correction capabilities, photo enhancement, layers, filters, and so on. And all this comes at an extremely affordable price. However, it loses out owing to its poor interface, and because of the better ease of use and a couple of additional features which Photoshop has recently added.

Photoshop also provides more filters, giving the user a wider choice to give fuller expression to his creativity. The action script makes one's job easier as one can record and play one's actions. It also has a set of predefined actions, which the user can apply to his work by just a click. Some additional features such as adding notes or audio annotation to images, text directly appearing on the user's screen and the predefined warping of text makes Photoshop stand apart from the rest of the image editing software.

At the end of the creative day, if one were to make a choice for that perfect digital imaging software, it would be nothing but Photoshop. 